

VIA CRUCIS

A story of Eboracum



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To the Latin scholars at St Constantine's

21 MARCH, 378
Holy Wednesday

I

The river is high today, Aurelius thought. The wind pushed him from behind and licked the edges of his cloak as he stared across the dappled water. The Isura was swollen to the top of its banks from the heavy Spring rain, which together with the melting snow rushed past the city of Eboracum to join with the smaller Fossa on its way to warmer climes, the water a sullen grey reflection of the sky. He imagined the way the sun used to bake the open fields in his native Gaul long ago, and shivered.

To his left and downstream, a boat made its way laboriously towards him by pole and by oar, the latter of which protruded from the sides of the vessel like the legs of a centipede. It rode heavy against both the current and the wind, the bow cleaving its way through the rushing water. Perched atop with a wide stance, a grizzly fellow in a heavily patched tunic twirled a circle of rope above his head with broad sweeps of his arm.

‘Ho there! Steady on!’ A hoarse cry came from the shore. Two other men, laborers from Eboracum, casually matched the crawling pace of the oncoming vessel, leading a sturdy ox between them. The distance between them and the boat gradually lessened; in another moment the rope was thrown, caught, and fastened to the yoke of the beast. They continued upstream at the same leisurely pace; but the oars were lifted, and the poling man at the stern, now

visible as the boat came alongside the wharf where Aurelius stood, only needed to guide the craft into position.

The wharf was crowded; too crowded, in fact. Aurelius retreated from the edge of the river, where an accidental shove might prove disastrous. He did not often come to the granary for unloading; it was usually sufficient, and certainly preferable, to delegate the task to a subordinate. But this was the first shipment of the season, and it was important to make sure it was portioned equitably between the troops garrisoned in the fortress of Eboracum and the civilian Colonia on the far side of the river. That was the official reason, anyway; but besides that, he (as much as anyone) simply wanted to see the shipment of grain for himself.

The commotion and clamour increased as the boat made ready to dock; many more hands than were necessary grasped at the ropes that were thrown to be tied to the quay. Aurelius felt the rising excitement of the crowd; at the same time, he instinctively searched for the insignia of the Praeses' guard.

The civilian labourers were generally trustworthy, he believed, and so were the rank-and-file soldiers stationed at Eboracum—even if he harboured a secret judgement that the *Legio VI Britannica* were not the fighting force they had once been when he first arrived in Eboracum many years ago, and under the elder Theodosius had pushed back the tribes of barbarians—Scots, Picts, and Saxons—beyond the Northern wall. Yes, they were good people. Nevertheless, any crowd were apt to be like the weather in Britannia: it could get unruly with little warning. And hunger can have a powerful effect on anyone, he thought.

But the *Principia* guards were there too, of course, marching down-river from the gated entrance of the fortress, and the crowd

gave way before them. They were a different breed, even from the average soldier: hand-picked by the Praeses himself, and openly displaying the red bull of the Victorious Legion. They commanded a respect that was immediate and total: indeed, even Aurelius himself could not remain unaffected by their presence. And yet, behind their efficient competency something seemed to be lacking.

Compassion, he thought—but immediately chastised himself. It was easy for him to judge, after all, when his days as a soldier were behind him. Was his judgement coloured by the knowledge that they still belonged to the old cult of Mithras? Despite the discouragement of pagan practices, it was an open secret that it remained a requirement for the position. But that did not mean they were bad people, he reminded himself. His own grandparents had been persecuted for their *Christian* faith; and now that it was not only tolerated in the Empire but even encouraged, he was determined not to repeat the sin of religious prejudice.

As he mused on these things his eye followed the heavy sacks of grain, one after the other, as they were handed on from boat to shore; and beneath them rushed the full flow of the Isura in its never-ending journey downstream.

‘Halt!’ A commanding voice jolted him back to the present. One of the guard—a man who stood a whole head taller than most of those around him—stood with one foot on the boards that formed a bridge between the boat and the stone wharf on which they stood. He had broken the human chain in two: in front of him stood the line of men leading to the cargo hold, who were still holding the sacks, but at the commanding voice of the soldier they stopped as if frozen, exchanging puzzled glances.

He became aware when he stopped speaking that the wharf was now wrapped in a tense silence. Although most of them were out of earshot of Aurelius' plea, he knew was only saying what most of them would, were they given the chance. He was speaking for them all. *And am I not Defensor Civitatis?* He reminded himself.

Severus matched his volume, but not his conciliatory tone. He took a step closer, accentuating the difference in height between them. 'Are you prepared to disobey Vindex, old man?' He said in a voice too low for anyone else to hear. 'How much do you value the grey hairs still left on your head?'

Aurelius opened his mouth to speak, but no words came. It was not the physical dominance of the young man that gave him a sudden tremour, nor his insolence—rather, it was the power behind the uniform which the soldier's confident assertion betrayed. There had always been tension between Principia and Colonia, soldier and civilian, neatly divided by the east and west bank of the Isura river. But there had also been respect—and restraint. *And if that is gone?* He wondered. It was as if the ground had somehow shifted beneath him.

Severus took advantage of the silence. 'You, there!' He called. 'How many modii of grain have been unloaded?'

The elderly man whom he addressed, thin and shriveled as a prune, sat hunched like a vulture over the frame of his abacus. His evidently poor eyesight obliged him to lean even further forward as he squinted to see the wooden beads in their tidy rows.

'Well now, let me see...324 of barley, 611 of wheat, and...' He leaned forward still further, and the little stool that he sat on wobbled precariously. '...112 of rye.' Satisfied, he righted himself and then craned his neck upwards to look at them, revealing a

guileless smile of brown and missing teeth, as if he expected a reward for his calculations.

Only 1,000 modii, Aurelius thought. *So little.*

‘Defensor,’ Severus continued, returning his attention to Aurelius, but also angling his head and projecting his voice to be heard by the crowd, as if he were an actor on the stage. ‘Do you concur?’

‘I concur that it is 1,047 modii,’ Aurelius said, finishing his mental calculation. At that the other snapped his fingers, and a young boy ran forward. With head appropriately bowed, he presented the paperwork to Aurelius. In his other hand he held a small pot of molten wax.

But Aurelius was not finished. ‘And I say again,’ he continued stubbornly, ‘that it is not enough. I cannot believe that the Dux would wish hardship on the people of Eboracum, who have already suffered so much. It is a mistake.’

‘And I say to you again, old man,’ the soldier growled, ‘That if you do not seal the document to accept delivery, I will bring you to Vindex myself on the charge of treason. Who will be Defensor in your place, I wonder?’

Aurelius looked around him at those present: men and women, soldiers and field laborers, children, even one or two stray dogs. All were wide-eyed and staring, and none, besides the Praeses’ guard, looking particularly well-fed. There was no denying that it had been an unusually hard winter—if he pressed his case now against this belligerent guard, would it help? Did it not have the potential to instead make things far worse?

It was possible that it was a mistake, after all—in that case, being arrested now would guarantee an audience with Vindex that

The crowd, too, murmured uneasily. Whispers of ‘Why have they stopped? What’s going on?’ echoed, and all eyes were fixed on the static line of men, still holding the precious sacks of grain. Aurelius elbowed his way through the people and made his way towards him.

‘Sir,’ he said when he reached him, ‘why have you stopped these men from unloading?’ It was an old habit of his: using the polite form when addressing another person, regardless of their rank. He saw the man stiffen at the sight of his official cloak and brooch, and realised his mistake. *He must think I am mocking him*, he thought.

But the soldier quickly recovered himself. ‘Orders, *Defensor*,’ he replied, emphasising the title. ‘The rest of the grain is to proceed North to the Dux.’

‘The Dux?’ Aurelius made a puzzled expression. ‘But he is supposed to be returning within a matter of days, not more than a week. Has he been delayed? Whose orders are these?’

‘From the Praeses, Defensor. Do you wish to see it?’ He motioned to one of his companions, who reached into his tunic.

‘No, no, I believe you—Severus, is it?’ The soldier started at the use of his name, then nodded.

Aurelius did not know the young man. But he had often found that knowing the names of prominent soldiers and city officials could be useful; and he intended now to appeal to his empathy. ‘Listen.’ He gestured at the people around him as he spoke. ‘These people are hungry—soldier and civilian alike—and the stores are low after a long winter. Perhaps Vindex does not realise...’

The soldier cut him off. ‘The *Praeses*,’ he corrected, ‘is in full awareness of the situation. The remainder of the grain will continue North. You may take up the matter with him.’

Aurelius scoffed, giving the first evidence of his frustration. ‘And by then they will be three days upriver! I know how hard it is to gain an audience at the Principia—’ *Especially when Vindex does not want to be found*, he stopped himself from adding.

Instead, he looked past the shoulders of the towering soldier, who he felt must be at least 20 years his junior, towards that ragged human chain that had been until now filling up the precious food stores of Eboracum. The sacks were now on the ground by their sides while they listened and waited for the outcome of the debate.

One of the *modii*, knotted and bound at the top with a label to testify to its weight, had not been sealed properly. As it sagged to one side, some of the contents began to escape: little pale grains of wheat trickled onto the wooden gangplank, and down into the river.

Lent had been long; and ashamed as he was for his weakness of appetite, Aurelius’ mouth watered as he imagined the taste of it. He was present on the wharf in official capacity, to guarantee the equitable distribution of the precious cargo—but he could not prevent his own motives from asserting themselves alongside those altruistic ones.

‘Look. Severus,’ he tried again—one last chance at diplomacy. ‘If they leave now with the rest of that shipment, the city will be on strict rations for weeks; perhaps longer. Children will go hungry. Perhaps you and I can visit the Praeses together? Between the two of us, I am certain that we could help him see reason.’

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would soon clear up the matter. But, as he faced Severus' proud demeanor, his heart told him otherwise.

He sighed, aware of his aching joints. More than anything, he wished himself back in his comfortable home, that expansive villa on the far side of the river. *Even in the week of the Saviour's passion, some respite is allowed, surely?*

He sighed, and instead of replying to Severus he turned to look down at the boy, whose curly hair covered his forehead and partly shielded his eyes.

'What is your name?' He asked.

'Aulus,' the boy replied.

'A good name! Tell me, Aulus: what will you be when you become a man?'

He unbowed his head and straightened to military attention. 'I want to be a soldier, sir. In the Praeses' guard.'

'Ah.' Aurelius thought again of the cult of Mithras and its tacit relationship to that role. The Emperor was a Christian, to be sure: but between Rome and Brittania Secunda lay not only a thousand miles, but also a dozen layers of governmental bureaucracy, each capable of sophisticated obfuscation when it was convenient. There was no escaping the fact that the old gods were alive and well in Eboracum. And what did that mean for the future of boys such as this?

He took the sheet of paper from the boy's hand and examined it. It was expensive, the colour of cream, and the numerals detailing the reception of the grain were clearly printed in black ink, only just dried. He rolled it up in one fist. Removing the signet from his right hand, he glanced out of habit at the carving of the wide-eyed owl on its face. Holding the scroll out to the boy, he waited while

he covered the open seam with the molten material. Then silently he pressed the signet into it, feeling the warm wax give under the gentle pressure as it took the seal. As he removed it, the owl's eyes stared back at him as if judging his actions.

'Kyrie, eleison,' he whispered in Greek, and gave the cylinder back to the boy.

He had meant to acknowledge Severus, but the latter had already turned away, as if having already forgotten his presence. He was already barking orders to the porters, who returned the sacks that had been in transit back to the hold of the ship and took themselves to the oars without argument. Aurelius watched them depart beneath a darkening sky.

He could not help but feel that something more significant than the sacks of grain had just been lost; he wondered if he might have done more to prevent it. Around him the crowd dispersed, while the remaining sacks were emptied alongside with the meagre remains of the winter supply in the granary, secure against both thieves and the coming storm. And Aurelius, too, turned towards home.

He received neither praise nor condemnation from the soldiers at the checkpoint as he passed onto the bridge; whatever regard they had for the Defensor and his role in the city was second now to the more immediate goal of getting out of the weather.

The rain began to fall in piercing, half-frozen drops as he crossed to the civilian Colonia. He pitied the boatmen, who would have been looking forward to following the current of the river back South, but instead were now pushing further north to where the *Dux Britanniarum*, commander of the Northern Legion, was

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supposedly waiting to receive them. Something didn't add up—but he decided it was a puzzle for tomorrow.

*And after all, he thought, pulling his cloak tighter around him.
Only four more days.*



This is the first chapter of *Via Crucis*, the debut novella from Christopher Bryan (better know as Subdeacon Maximos!) Husband and father of three, he serves as protopsaltis and choir director at St Constantine's Antiochian Orthodox parish in York, England.

To receive a free copy of *Via Crucis* when it is available, please consider supporting our building fund! We are endeavouring to purchase St Martin-cum-Gregory's historic church on Mickelgate, in the vicinity of the Roman Colonia featured in this story.

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